

Topic Reading

Climate Change



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Without looking at a dictionary, what are the differences in meaning between these words: information, misinformation and disinformation?
How can these be damaging to public debate?

Types of false information



Disinformation
deliberate lie to mislead

Misinformation
honest mistake

Look at the text by Lewandowsky (2021): 'Climate Change Disinformation and how to Combat it'.

- Who wrote the text? What is their background?
- Where was the text published?
- When was the text published?

Abstract



Read the first four sentences of the abstract:

Climate change presents a challenge at multiple levels. It challenges our cognitive abilities because the effect of the accumulation of emissions is difficult to understand. Climate change also challenges many people's worldview because any climate mitigation regime will have economic and political implications that are incompatible with libertarian ideals of unregulated free markets. These political implications have created an environment of rhetorical adversity in which disinformation abounds, thus compounding the challenges for climate communicators.

- Do you agree that climate change challenges our cognitive abilities? If so, what do you think can be done about this?
- Do you agree that “any climate mitigation regime will have economic and political implications that are incompatible with libertarian ideals of unregulated free markets”? Do you remember what Professor Eric Neumeyer's view was? (Topic Listening)

“A lot of things that would be good for more liberalised trade and investment would also be good for the environment...trade can be a positive force for the environment”



Abstract



Read the second part of the abstract:

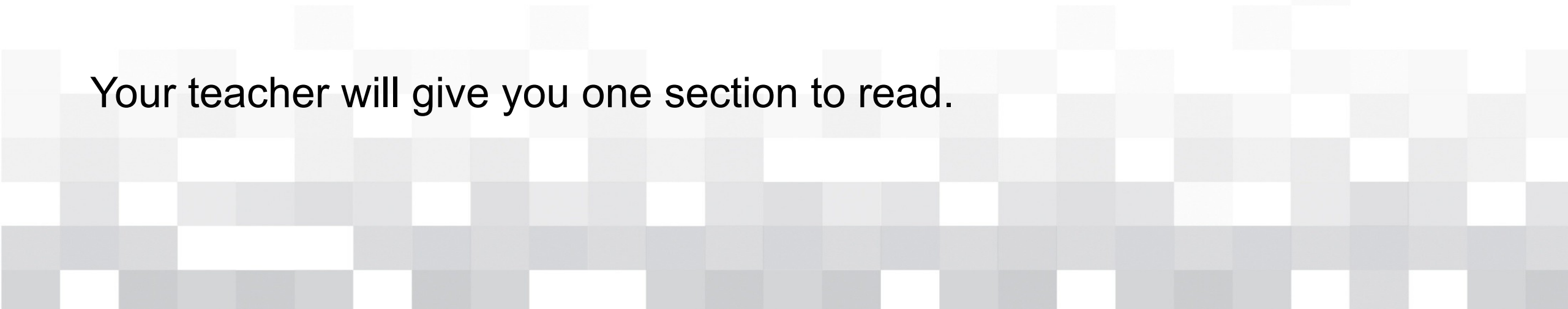
The existing literature on how to communicate climate change and **dispel** misinformation **converges on** several conclusions: First, providing information about climate change, in particular explanations of why it occurs, can **enhance** people's acceptance of science. Second, highlighting the scientific consensus can be an effective means **to counter** misinformation and raise public acceptance. Third, **culturally aligned** messages and messengers are more likely to be successful. Finally, climate misinformation is best **defanged**, through a process known as **inoculation**, before it is **encountered**, although **debunking techniques** can also be successful.

Check that you understand the vocabulary in blue.

The text has 4 main sections.

1. Climate change: physical science versus social cognition
2. Climate change versus human cognition
3. Climate science versus disinformation
4. Communicating climate change in an adversarial environment

Your teacher will give you one section to read.

A decorative pattern of light and dark gray squares, resembling a pixelated or mosaic effect, located at the bottom of the slide.

Read the section using the SQ3R Method (Survey, Question, Read, Recite, Review)

1. **Survey:** skim the section paying attention to headings, subheadings, and key terms.
2. **Question:** use the headings to predict the content and ask yourself questions
3. **Read:** read to find answers.
4. **Recite:** when you finish a sub-section, check whether you can summarise the key points aloud or in writing
5. **Review:** when you have read the whole section, review the key points and evaluate what you have read: what have you learned; do you agree/disagree with the author; do you have any questions or need more information; did you find any useful vocabulary....?

Share your findings with students who read the other sections. Make sure you end up with an understanding of the full text.



Discussion



In pairs, consider the questions below:

1. In the conclusion to Lewandowsky's paper, he writes:

Communication by scientists and their allies by itself will not move climate mitigation forward. As sociologist Robert Brulle (2017) notes, "the barriers to action on climate change are based in the distribution of social power in the economic, political, and cultural spheres. Introducing new messages or information into an otherwise unchanged socioeconomic system will accomplish little" (p. 185). But socioeconomic and political systems are not immune to change. A Swedish school girl taught the world that lesson in 2019.

What is the name of the Swedish school girl? What did she do? Do you agree that she taught the world a lesson in 2019? If so, what was that lesson?

2. "According to Davis (2021), "humanity has been put in a perilous position because those in power have delayed, denied and misled". To what extent do you agree with this claim?
2. What are some of the main ways in which climate change disinformation is spread in societies? Can you think of some solutions to combat this?